

Beliefs about Refugee Integration in Germany: A Survey Experiment on Ukrainian and Syrian Refugees

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1 Introduction

2 Literature Review and Conceptual Framework

2.1 Immigration Attitudes and Migrant Characteristics

A large literature examines how host-country populations evaluate migrants and which characteristics shape these evaluations. One central distinction in this literature is based on whether attitudes toward migrants primarily reflect individuals' own economic interests and labor-market considerations or characteristics of the migrants.

Earlier economic studies provide some evidence that labor-market considerations are associated with immigration preferences (e.g., Scheve and Slaughter, 2001; Mayda, 2006). Beyond economic self-interest, immigration attitudes have also been linked to broader fiscal, cultural, and group-related concerns (Burns and Gimpel, 2000; Dustmann and Preston, 2007; Sides and Citrin, 2007). Reviewing this literature, Hainmueller and Hopkins (2014) conclude that evidence for explanations based on individual economic self-interest is generally limited.

Experimental evidence further challenges a simple labor-market competition explanation and rather points to the importance of migrants' own characteristics. Hainmueller and Hiscox (2010) find that both high- and low-skilled natives prefer high-skilled over low-skilled immigrants. If immigration attitudes were primarily driven by competition with similarly skilled workers, preferences would be expected to differ according to respondents' own skill levels. Instead, the common preference for high-skilled immigration suggests that respondents place considerable weight on migrants' human capital and potential economic contribution. This pattern is also found in multidimensional experiments. Higher education, occupational status, employability, and language proficiency are generally associated with more favorable evaluations of migrants (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; Bansak et al., 2016; Czymara and Schmidt-Catran, 2016). More recent evidence from Germany similarly shows greater willingness to accept skilled economic migrants with recognized professional qualifications, good language skills, and a definite job offer (Wolff et al., 2025). Taken together, these studies show that characteristics associated with migrants' expected labor-market integration play an important role in how they are evaluated.

Country of origin, cultural and religious background, and migration status also influence attitudes when other characteristics are held constant. Hainmueller and Hopkins (2015) find differences in evaluations across immigrants' countries of origin alongside effects of education, occupation, and English proficiency. In the European context, Bansak et al. (2016) show that preferences over asylum seekers depend jointly on country of origin, religion, employability, and vulnerability. Similar patterns emerge in Germany. Czymara and Schmidt-Catran (2016) find that acceptance varies with migrants' country of origin and reason for migration as well as their education and German-language proficiency.

These studies show that evaluations depend not only on migrants’ individual characteristics, but also on broader group-related characteristics and migration categories.

Although much of this literature focuses on attitudes and preferences toward migrants rather than beliefs about their expected outcomes, it shows that evaluations vary systematically with migrants’ observable characteristics. In line with this literature, higher human capital and stronger language proficiency may similarly serve as signals when respondents form expectations about migrants’ economic and social integration. This leads to the first hypotheses:

H1a: Holding other migrant characteristics constant, respondents expect migrants with higher human capital to achieve more favorable labor-market integration outcomes than migrants with lower human capital.

H1b: Holding other migrant characteristics constant, respondents expect migrants with higher German-language proficiency to achieve more favorable labor-market and social-integration outcomes than migrants with lower German-language proficiency.

2.2 Beliefs and Expectations about Migrant Outcomes

A growing literature shows that individuals hold systematic beliefs about immigrants and their economic and social characteristics. Much of this research examines perceptions of immigrant populations as a whole, including their size, composition, education, and employment (Sides and Citrin, 2007; Alesina et al., 2023). Respondents tend to overestimate the share of immigrants living in their country, and perceive immigrants as less educated, more unemployed, and more dependent on government transfers than they actually are. However, these perceptions may depend on which types of migrants respondents have in mind. Blinder (2015) shows that public understandings of the term “immigrant” do not necessarily correspond to the full migrant population, with some migrant categories being considerably more salient than others. This suggests that treating migrants as a single category may obscure differences in how distinct types of migrants are perceived.

One particularly relevant distinction concerns migrants’ reasons for migration. Evaluations vary between refugees and migrants arriving for economic reasons (Czymara and Schmidt-Catran, 2016). Previous research on refugee labor-market integration examines several dimensions of migrants’ economic outcomes, including employment, earnings, and occupational outcomes (Brell et al., 2020; Fasani et al., 2024). These studies find that refugees tend to experience less favorable outcomes along these dimensions than economic migrants. Although this evidence concerns evaluations or actual outcomes rather than beliefs about future integration, it provides reason to expect that host-country populations may also distinguish between otherwise comparable refugees and economic migrants when forming such expectations. This leads to the following hypothesis:

H2: Holding all other migrant characteristics constant, respondents expect refugees to achieve less favorable labor-market integration outcomes than economic migrants.

A related literature examines migrants' employability and labor-market experiences and shows that employment outcomes depend not only on migrants' individual characteristics, but also on organizational and institutional factors in the host country (Shirmohammadi et al., 2019; Farashah et al., 2023). Research on immigrant recruitment further demonstrates that employers' perceptions can shape migrants' employment opportunities and that migrant workers may face discrimination and disadvantages in hiring and occupational outcomes (Almeida et al., 2015; Dietz et al., 2015). However, this literature primarily examines migrants' actual labor-market experiences or employers' recruitment decisions rather than expectations held by the broader host-country population.

A smaller literature comes closer to examining such expectations from the perspective of the host-country population. Niemann et al. (2024), for example, study how working adults in Germany form expectations about migrants' occupational future and integration efforts depending on migrant characteristics such as origin, skill level, and reason for migration. Related research demonstrates that individuals also hold beliefs about discrimination. Haaland and Roth (2023) document substantial heterogeneity in beliefs about racial discrimination in hiring in the United States. Although their study concerns racial discrimination rather than migration, it demonstrates the conceptual distinction between beliefs about discrimination and actual discriminatory behavior.

Taken together, existing research provides evidence on several individual dimensions of migrants' expected integration, but evidence examining expectations across multiple economic and social outcomes remains limited. This thesis contributes to this literature by examining expectations concerning employment, income, discrimination, and social integration for Ukrainian and Syrian refugee migrants and economic migrants in Germany.

2.3 Differential Perceptions of Ukrainian and Syrian Migrants

Earlier literature shows that responses to refugees in Germany already differed across groups and changed over time during and after the 2015–2016 refugee inflow. In particular, country of origin was associated with differences in acceptance of refugees, while other characteristics such as migration circumstances and family composition also shaped public responses (Bansak et al., 2016; Czymara and Schmidt-Catran, 2016, 2017; Plener et al., 2017; Liebe et al., 2018). Czymara and Schmidt-Catran (2017), for example, show that following the events of New Year's Eve 2015/2016, the acceptance of refugees generally increased, whereas the acceptance of immigrants of North African and Arab origin declined. Other research demonstrates that attitudes also varied with local exposure to the refugee inflow. Albarosa and Elsner (2023), for instance, document heterogeneous changes in attitudes across German regions depending on the size of the local refugee inflow. Looking at a later period, Przechomski et al. (2026) find that, after an initial increase in negative sentiment, attitudes gradually became more positive between 2017 and 2021.

The arrival of Ukrainian refugees following Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022 pro-

vided a new context for examining differences in responses to refugee groups in Europe. Existing research demonstrates that Ukrainian refugees have generally received more favorable public and institutional responses than Syrian refugees (Moise et al., 2024; Drewski and Gerhards, 2025; Das, 2025). Evidence from Germany similarly shows greater willingness to help Ukrainian refugees, more positive perceptions of their warmth and integration prospects, and greater solidarity toward them than toward Syrian refugees (Echterhoff et al., 2023; Schmidt et al., 2024; Stefaniak et al., 2025). These findings therefore suggest that public responses are shaped not only by refugee status itself but also by refugees' country of origin.

Several explanations have been proposed for these differences. Theories of group position and perceived group threat suggest that attitudes toward immigrant groups depend partly on how these groups are positioned and perceived relative to the host population. Building on the group-position perspective of Blumer (1958), Quillian (1995) argues that prejudice can reflect perceived collective threat and the relative position of the in-group and out-group. In the context of Ukrainian and Syrian migrants, existing studies similarly point to differences in perceived cultural similarity, threat, and deservingness (Echterhoff et al., 2023; Schmidt et al., 2024; Stefaniak et al., 2025). At the broader political level, Drewski and Gerhards (2025) show that Syrian and Ukrainian refugees were framed differently in Germany and Poland and link these differences to cultural and geopolitical factors that shaped state responses to the two groups.

These findings provide reason to expect that these differences between Ukrainian and Syrian migrants may also be reflected in beliefs about their integration outcomes. In line with this literature, I develop the following hypothesis:

H3a: Holding other migrant characteristics constant, respondents expect Ukrainian migrants to achieve more favorable labor-market and social integration outcomes than Syrian migrants.

In addition, the previous discussion in Section 2.2 provides reason to expect that individuals also form beliefs about the discrimination in labor-market outcomes of migrants. Combined with the less favorable perceptions of Syrian relative to Ukrainian migrants documented in this section, I developed the following hypothesis:

H3b: Holding other migrant characteristics constant, respondents expect Syrian migrants to face greater discrimination in the German labor market than Ukrainian migrants.

Further, I am interested in whether the difference between Ukrainian and Syrian migrants may depend on their reason for migration. Much of the literature above discussing differential responses toward the two groups concerns refugees specifically, suggesting that country of origin may be particularly important when migrants are evaluated in a refugee context. By contrast, evaluations of economic migrants may place relatively greater weight on characteristics related to their expected economic contribution and may not differ significantly by the country of origin. I therefore develop the following hypothesis:

H3c: Differences between Ukrainian and Syrian migrants in expected integration and discrimination outcomes are greater when migrants are presented as refugees than when they are presented as economic migrants.

In addition, I explore whether differences between Ukrainian and Syrian migrants vary with their level of human capital, and in particular whether higher human capital reduces the country-of-origin gap in expected integration outcomes.

2.4 Belief Formation Through Contact, Experience, Information, and Memory

Intergroup contact is one potential source from which individuals form perceptions of migrant groups. The contact hypothesis, originating with Allport (1954), proposes that contact between members of different groups can reduce prejudice under optimal contact conditions. A large subsequent literature generally finds an association between intergroup contact and lower prejudice, with Pettigrew and Tropp (2006) showing that these effects are not limited to situations in which all of Allport’s original conditions are satisfied. Evidence from migration and refugee contexts similarly shows that direct contact is associated with more favorable evaluations of migrants and refugees (Kotzur et al., 2019; De Coninck et al., 2021; Khalil and Naumann, 2022).

However, the amount of contact alone may not capture how intergroup experiences relate to perceptions. Contact can generate both positive and negative experiences, making it important to distinguish the frequency of contact from its valence. Positive contact is generally associated with more favorable attitudes toward migrants and refugees, whereas negative contact is associated with less favorable attitudes and behavioral tendencies (Laurence and Bentley, 2018; Kotzur et al., 2019; Bagci et al., 2023). De Coninck et al. (2021) similarly distinguish between the frequency and valence of intergroup contact and find that contact valence is particularly important for attitudes toward refugees. Moreover, increased exposure does not necessarily produce more favorable responses (Enos, 2019; Hangartner et al., 2019). Taken together, this literature suggests that the nature of respondents’ experiences with migrant groups may be more informative than exposure alone. I therefore develop the following hypothesis:

H4a: Conditional on contact frequency, more positive overall personal experiences with a migrant group are associated with more favorable beliefs about that group’s integration outcomes.

The importance of contact valence is consistent with a broader literature showing that personal social experiences can shape subsequent beliefs and behavior. Schwerter and Zimmermann (2020) experimentally show that positive and negative social experiences lead to substantial differences in subsequent willingness to trust, with beliefs about others’ trustworthiness playing an important role in these effects. However, the valence of contact

may also matter asymmetrically. In the intergroup-contact literature, Paolini et al. (2024) provide evidence that negative contact is more strongly associated with increased prejudice than positive contact is with reduced prejudice. Building on this evidence, I expect a similar asymmetry in the relationship between personal experiences with migrant groups and beliefs about their integration outcomes. This leads to the following hypothesis:

H4b: Negative personal experiences with a migrant group are more strongly associated with unfavorable beliefs about that group's integration outcomes than positive personal experiences are associated with favorable beliefs.

Personal experiences, however, are not the only source of information from which individuals may form beliefs about migrant groups. Experimental evidence shows that information about immigrants and refugees can influence subsequent perceptions and attitudes, although the direction and magnitude of these effects depend on the information provided and respondents' prior beliefs (Hayo and Neumeier, 2023; Dylong and Uebelmesser, 2026; Guenther, 2024). Media constitute a particularly important source of such information, providing indirect exposure to migrant groups even in the absence of direct personal contact (Schiappa et al., 2005; De Coninck et al., 2021). As with personal contact, the relationship between media exposure and attitudes may depend not only on the amount of exposure but also on its content and framing, as media representations of immigrants and refugees differ systematically in the economic, cultural, or security-related threats they emphasize (Atwell Seate and Mastro, 2016; Jacobs et al., 2016). Moreover, media exposure may itself be selective, as individuals may choose refugee-related media content based on their existing views (Lueders et al., 2019). Therefore, similar to the hypothesis about contact valence (H4a), I develop the following hypothesis:

H5: Conditional on media-exposure frequency, more positive overall media information concerning a migrant group is associated with more favorable beliefs about that group's integration outcomes.

Finally, past experiences and information may not receive equal weight when individuals form current beliefs. Models of associative memory suggest that recall is selective and cue-dependent, such that experiences related to the current context are more likely to come to mind and influence beliefs (Bordalo et al., 2023; Enke et al., 2024). Consistent with this mechanism, Graeber et al. (2024) further show that stories are more readily recalled than statistical information and consequently remain more influential on beliefs over time. Applied to the migration context, beliefs about Ukrainian and Syrian migrants may therefore depend not only on respondents' overall exposure to and experiences with each group, but also on the personal experiences and media information that are especially memorable and on the valence of these memories. This leads to my last hypotheses:

H6a: Conditional on contact frequency and overall experience valence, the valence of respondents' most memorable personal experience with a migrant group is associated with

beliefs about that group’s integration outcomes.

H6b: Conditional on media-exposure frequency and overall media valence, the valence of respondents’ most memorable media information about a migrant group is associated with beliefs about that group’s integration outcomes.

3 Experimental Design

This thesis proposes a survey experiment to examine how Germans form beliefs about the labor-market and social integration outcomes of Ukrainian and Syrian migrants. The proposed study consists of a factorial vignette experiment, a set of outcome measures, and a respondent questionnaire. The following sections describe each part of the proposed experimental design and the survey procedure.

3.1 Target Population and Proposed Sample

The target population consists of German citizens aged 18 or older who currently reside in Germany. Restricting eligibility to German citizens provides a clear operational definition of the German population whose beliefs about the integration of Ukrainian and Syrian migrants are the focus of this study. Similar citizenship-based sampling criteria have been used in previous studies examining attitudes toward refugees and migration in Germany (e.g., Hayo and Neumeier, 2023). Importantly, German citizenship is not used as a proxy for being native-born or having no migration background. Naturalized German citizens are therefore included in the target population, while respondents’ migration background is collected separately as a demographic characteristic in the respondent questionnaire. At the beginning of the survey, respondents would therefore be screened with respect to age, country of residence, and German citizenship. Respondents who do not satisfy these eligibility criteria would not proceed to the experimental part of the survey.

I propose using Qualtrics to program the survey, and the online panel provider Bilendi for the recruitment of participants. Bilendi is suitable for the present study because it provides access to a large and diverse pool of respondents in Germany and allows the use of demographic quotas to approximate the composition of the target population. The proposed sample would use quotas for age, gender, education, and region. Respondents would receive compensation for their participation according to the standard compensation provided by the panel, taking into account the expected duration of the survey.

The final sample size would be determined based on a power analysis of the proposed experimental design. The number of vignette evaluations per respondent, which also affects the required sample size, is discussed in Section 3.2.

3.2 Factorial Vignette Design

The proposed study employs a factorial vignette experiment in which respondents evaluate hypothetical migrants whose characteristics are independently varied across profiles. This approach is particularly suitable for the present research question because migrants differ simultaneously along several characteristics. By independently varying these characteristics, the design makes it possible to distinguish their effects on respondents' beliefs while holding the remaining characteristics constant. The proposed design builds on previous conjoint and factorial vignette experiments examining how migrant characteristics shape evaluations (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; Bansak et al., 2016; Czymara and Schmidt-Catran, 2016).

The proposed vignettes describe migrants who have come to Germany and are currently looking for stable employment. Each profile varies independently along five binary dimensions: gender, country of origin, reason for migration, human capital, and German-language proficiency. These vignette attributes are selected to capture migrant characteristics that are central to the research questions and that previous research has shown to influence perceptions of migrants. Country of origin is varied between (1) Ukrainian and (2) Syrian migrants and represents the central comparison of the study. Reason for migration distinguishes between the two types of migrants: (1) refugees who fled the wars in Ukraine or Syria and (2) economic migrants who came to Germany in search of better employment opportunities. Educational attainment captures differences in migrants' human capital, which previous vignette and conjoint studies have shown to influence evaluations of immigrants (Hainmueller and Hiscox, 2010; Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; Czymara and Schmidt-Catran, 2016). The design distinguishes between (1) migrants without a formal vocational qualification and (2) migrants with a university degree. German-language proficiency is varied between (1) limited and (2) good German skills. Language proficiency may be relevant both for social integration and for labor-market outcomes, since knowledge of the host-country language represents an important form of human capital (Czymara and Schmidt-Catran, 2016). Finally, gender distinguishes between (1) male and (2) female migrants. Gender is included because previous experimental research suggests that migrant gender can affect how immigrants and refugees are perceived, including in the German context (Czymara and Schmidt-Catran, 2017; Gereke et al., 2020). Randomizing gender therefore allows the effects of the other vignette characteristics to be estimated across both male and female migrant profiles.

As discussed previously, existing research shows that religion and perceived cultural distance can influence attitudes toward immigrants (e.g., Czymara and Schmidt-Catran, 2016). However, in this study, religious affiliation is deliberately left unspecified. The main interest of this thesis is in the overall beliefs that respondents associate with Ukrainian and Syrian migrants. Explicitly including religion as an additional vignette attribute would not only make the design more complex, but could also change the beliefs that respondents would otherwise associate with the migrant's country of origin. For this reason, religion

is not varied separately in the experiment. The estimated country-of-origin effect should therefore be interpreted as an overall effect of Ukrainian versus Syrian origin, which may also reflect perceived cultural or religious differences between the two groups.

Table 1 summarizes the five vignette attributes and their respective levels and shows how the randomized characteristics relate to the hypotheses developed in Chapter 2.

Table 1: Vignette Attributes and Attribute Levels

Vignette attribute	Level 1	Level 2	Hypothesis
Country of origin	Syria	Ukraine	H3a, H3b, H3c
Reason for migration	Economic migrant	War refugee	H2, H3c
Human capital	No formal vocational qualification	University degree	H1a
German-language proficiency	Limited	Good	H1b
Gender	Male	Female	—

Notes: The table presents the five independently randomized attributes used to construct the migrant profiles. Gender is included as an additional randomized characteristic but is not associated with a separate hypothesis.

The five binary attributes generate a full factorial design of $2^5 = 32$ possible migrant profiles. The vignettes would be worded as follows:

A [male/female] from [Ukraine/Syria] came to Germany. [He/She] came to Germany as [a refugee after fleeing the war in his/her country / an economic migrant in search of better employment and economic opportunities in Germany]. [He/She] [has no formal vocational qualification / has completed a university degree], speaks German [only to a limited extent / well], and is currently looking for stable employment.

Since evaluating all possible profiles would place a substantial burden on respondents, I propose that each respondent evaluate a randomly selected subset of six vignettes. This provides several profile evaluations per respondent while keeping the survey manageable, particularly because each vignette is followed by several belief questions about migrant outcomes. The choice therefore reflects a trade-off between obtaining sufficient statistical information and limiting cognitive burden and respondent fatigue, which are important considerations in factorial survey designs (Sauer et al., 2011). The exact number of vignettes could be further assessed through pilot testing.

Prior to implementation, the survey would be pilot tested with approximately 50 respondents from the target population. The pilot would be used to assess survey completion time, attrition, potential respondent fatigue, and the performance of the attention and

data-quality checks. It would also be used to ensure that the vignette wording, questions, and response scales are understandable and that the Qualtrics randomization functions correctly. In particular, dropout patterns and response times across the survey would be examined to assess whether six vignette evaluations can reasonably be completed without imposing excessive burden. Based on the pilot results and respondent feedback, the exact number of vignettes and, where necessary, the wording or survey structure could be adjusted before the main study. The order in which the vignette profiles are presented to each respondent would also be randomized.

3.3 Outcome Variables

The five outcome questions would be answered right after each vignette. They are designed to capture respondents' beliefs about the labor-market, discrimination, and social-integration outcomes of the migrant described in each profile.

The outcomes cover three aspects: beliefs about labor-market integration outcomes (expected employment and expected income), beliefs about labor-market discrimination (expected hiring and workplace treatment), and beliefs about social integration. The exact wording of all outcome questions and response scales is provided in Appendix [X].

The first two outcome questions capture beliefs about the migrant's labor-market integration. As discussed in Section 2.2, labor-market integration is reflected in several dimensions, including employment, earnings, and occupational outcomes (Brell et al., 2020; Fasani et al., 2024). Therefore, to capture the clearest and the most interpretable dimensions, the proposed experiment measures respondents' beliefs about labor-market integration based on expected employment and expected income. First, respondents state the probability that the migrant will find regular paid employment subject to social security contributions within the next two years. The type of employment in this question is formulated in a way to exclude informal, marginal, or unstable jobs. The timeframe of two years is chosen because it is long enough for job search, language learning, and recognition of qualifications of the migrants in Germany, but still short enough for respondents to imagine. Responses would be recorded on a scale from 0 to 100 percent. This probability scale provides a direct quantitative measure of respondents' beliefs about employment prospects. Second, respondents indicate the migrant's expected monthly net income five years from now by selecting one of seven income categories.

Two additional measures capture respondents' beliefs about discrimination in the German labor market. The first concerns hiring discrimination and asks respondents how likely is it that the migrant would be treated less favorably in the hiring process than an otherwise comparable German applicant. The second concerns discrimination after entering employment and measures the expected likelihood of unequal treatment in the workplace, for example in areas such as wages, promotion opportunities, or interactions with colleagues. Both outcomes are measured on seven-point scales, with higher values indicating greater agreement and therefore higher expected discrimination.

The final outcome captures beliefs about social integration. Respondents assess how likely the migrant is to successfully integrate socially in Germany within the next five years. To give respondents a common understanding of social integration, the question defines it as the migrants building regular social contacts with German citizens within the next five years. Responses are recorded on a seven-point scale, with higher values indicating more favorable beliefs about social integration.

Combined, these five measures capture different dimensions of respondents' beliefs about migrant integration rather than a single overall evaluation. The labor-market variables provide the main outcomes for H1a, H1b, H2, and H3a, while the discrimination measures provide the outcomes for H3b and the social-integration measure provides an additional outcome for H1b and H3a. All five outcome measures are used to examine H3c. In the empirical analysis, the outcome measures are analyzed separately rather than being combined into a single integration index.

3.4 Respondent Questionnaire

After answering all outcome questions for the vignette profiles, respondents would complete an additional questionnaire measuring personal contact experiences, media exposure, general beliefs, and their background characteristics. These questions are specifically asked after the vignette experiment to avoid influencing respondents' answers to the vignettes. For questions that are asked separately for Ukrainian and Syrian migrants, the order of the two groups would be randomized where feasible.

3.4.1 Personal Contact and Experience.

Contact frequency. Respondents are asked separately about the frequency of workplace and non-work contact with Ukrainian and Syrian migrants during the past 12 months. Non-work contact refers to interactions outside of a workplace setting, for example as friends, neighbours, acquaintances, through clubs, or in other social settings. Both questions use the same seven-point frequency scale ranging from 1 (never) to 7 (several times per day). For more details on the exact wording of the questions and response scales, see Appendix [X]. For each migrant group, the two measures are combined into an overall contact exposure measure C_{ig} :

$$C_{ig} = \frac{C_{ig}^{\text{Work}} + C_{ig}^{\text{Non-Work}}}{2},$$

where C_{ig}^{Work} and $C_{ig}^{\text{Non-Work}}$ denote workplace and non-work contact, respectively, for respondent i and migrant group g , where $g \in \{\text{Ukrainian, Syrian}\}$. Higher values indicate more frequent overall contact with the respective group. If a person is retired, unemployed, a student, or not currently working, they would answer that workplace contact is not applicable for them and it would be marked as missing instead of reporting it as never having contact with the migrant group in the workplace.

This contact measure can be used in the specifications for H4–H6, because these hypotheses concern respondents’ overall contact experiences with the migrant group. Additionally, the two contact types can be analyzed separately to examine whether workplace and non-work contact are differently associated with respondents’ beliefs because contact in the workplace is not necessarily comparable to social contact with friends or neighbours.

Overall contact quality. If respondents report having had contact with Ukrainian or Syrian migrants, they are asked to evaluate the overall quality of their contact experiences with each group. The question is answered on a seven-point scale ranging from 1 (very negative) to 7 (very positive), with 4 representing a neutral experience that is neither positive nor negative. This measure is denoted by Q_{ig} and is used to examine H4a, conditional on respondents’ overall contact exposure C_{ig} .

To examine whether negative experiences are more strongly associated with respondents’ beliefs than positive experiences, as proposed in H4b, the overall experience measure is additionally separated into positive and negative components:

$$\begin{aligned} Positive_{ig} &= \max(Q_{ig} - 4, 0), \\ Negative_{ig} &= \max(4 - Q_{ig}, 0). \end{aligned}$$

where $Positive_{ig}$ captures the positivity of respondents’ overall contact experiences and $Negative_{ig}$ captures the negativity of respondents’ overall contact experiences. Both of them are designed to range from 0 to 3 with higher values indicating more positive or negative experiences, respectively. Both take the value zero from a neutral response of $Q_{ig} = 4$. These separate measures make it possible to examine whether negative and positive experiences are differently associated with respondents’ beliefs.

Most memorable experience. If respondents report having had contact with Ukrainian or Syrian migrants, they are also asked to state whether a particular experience immediately comes to mind when thinking about their personal experiences. They would only respond with “Yes” or “No”.

Valence of most memorable experience. If their answer is “Yes”, they are asked to evaluate this most memorable experience, denoted by E_{ig} , on a seven-point scale. The valence of the most memorable experience is denoted by V_{ig}^E and is used to examine H6a while controlling for overall contact frequency and quality. For respondents who report having had contact with a migrant group but do not have a particular experience that comes to mind, V_{ig}^E is coded as missing.

3.4.2 Media Exposure and Information.

Media exposure. Respondents are asked how often they come across information about Ukrainian and Syrian migrants living in Germany through media channels such as television, newspapers, online news, social media, radio, podcasts, etc. The question is asked

separately for each migrant group using a seven-point scale ranging from 1 (never) to 7 (several times per day). The resulting measure of media-exposure frequency is denoted by M_{ig} , with higher values indicating more frequent exposure to media information.

Overall media tone. Respondents are then asked to evaluate the tone (valence) of the media information they have encountered about each migrant group using a seven-point scale ranging from 1 (very negative) to 7 (very positive), with 4 representing neutral or balanced information. The resulting measure, T_{ig} , captures the perceived tone of the media information. This measure is used to examine H5 while controlling for the frequency of media exposure M_{ig} .

Most memorable media information. If respondents have had media exposure, similar to the most memorable personal experience, respondents are asked whether a particular piece of media information immediately comes to mind. They would respond with either “Yes” or “No”. The most memorable piece of media information is denoted by I_{ig} which stands for information.

Valence of most memorable media information. Respondents who recall a particular piece of media information, I_{ig} , are asked to evaluate it on a seven-point scale. The valence of the most memorable media information is denoted by V_{ig}^I , with higher values indicating more positive recalled information. This measure is used to examine H6b while controlling for media-exposure frequency and overall media tone.

The measures of memorable personal experiences and media information differ from controlled experimental settings in which researchers manipulate the experiences participants encounter (Schwerter and Zimmermann, 2020) or observe the information participants receive and can subsequently assess recall against this information (Graeber et al., 2024). In the present thesis, both personal experiences and media information exposure occur naturally as positive or negative experiences in the lives of the respondents and are not observed by the researcher. The measures therefore capture respondents’ current subjective evaluations of the information that is most salient in memory rather than its objective valence or recall accuracy. This is relevant for the present thesis because the focus is on how respondents’ own perceptions of certain experiences and information are associated with their beliefs.

3.4.3 General Beliefs About Integration.

The questionnaire also includes some questions on more general group-level beliefs about the integration of Ukrainian and Syrian migrants in Germany, capturing respondents’ broader perceptions of the two migrant groups. These measures are not used as primary outcomes for H1–H6. Instead, they can be used in descriptive and exploratory analyses that may help interpret mechanism behind why respondents’ beliefs differ between Ukrainians and Syrians.

Integration over time. Integration itself can also develop with time spent in the host country and can also differ across dimensions such as labor-market and social integration. Previous research shows that migrants’ labor-market integration tends to improve with duration of residence, including through higher employment and earnings, while initial labor-market disadvantages can narrow over time (Brücker et al., 2020; Fasani et al., 2022). There is also supporting evidence for social integration improving over time. Longer residence can be associated with greater interaction with the host-country population and stronger social integration (Niehues et al., 2021; Hannafi and Marouani, 2023). Such developments may also shape the beliefs of the general German population about whether migrants become better integrated the longer they live in Germany.

Therefore, the questionnaire is designed to measure these two beliefs. Respondents are asked whether they agree with the statements that (1) migrants become better integrated into the German labor market the longer they live in Germany, and that (2) they become more socially integrated the longer they live in Germany. Responses are evaluated on a seven-point scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree). The resulting measures are denoted by $TimeLM_i$ and $TimeSoc_i$, capturing general beliefs that labor-market and social integration, respectively, improve with duration of residence.

Establishment of Co-Ethnic Communities. The potential role of co-ethnic networks may depend on how established migrant communities are perceived to be. Respondents are therefore asked whether they agree that the Ukrainian and Syrian communities in Germany are well established. Responses are recorded on a seven-point scale. The resulting measure is denoted by $Comm_{ig}$, with higher values indicating a stronger belief that the respective migrant community is well established in Germany.

Community Networks: Labor-Market Facilitation. Respondents may hold significant beliefs about the different integration outcomes associated with community networks. The first mechanism is that co-ethnic communities may facilitate migrants’ labor-market integration by providing access to information and personal networks that can help them find employment. Evidence from Germany shows that immigrants located in areas with larger co-ethnic networks are more likely to find employment shortly after arrival and are more likely to find their first job through personal contacts (Battisti et al., 2022). Respondents are therefore asked whether they agree that co-ethnic communities in Germany help newly arrived migrants find employment using a seven-point scale. The measure is denoted by $FacilEmp_{ig}$.

Community Networks: Reduced Interaction with Germans. The second mechanism is that co-ethnic communities may also affect social integration by reducing migrants’ interaction with the host-country population. Evidence from Germany suggests that greater access to co-ethnic communities can reduce social interaction with natives and may also negatively affect the language ability of migrants (Danzer and Yaman, 2013, 2016). Respondents are therefore asked whether they agree with the statement that be-

ing able to rely on established Ukrainian and Syrian communities reduces the need for newly arrived migrants to interact regularly with Germans. Responses are recorded on a seven-point scale. The resulting measure is denoted by $RedInt_{ig}$.

3.4.4 Respondent Controls.

Lastly, the questionnaire collects respondent controls which are standard demographic and socioeconomic characteristics. These include respondents' age, gender, education, employment status, household income, region of residence in Germany, migration background, religious affiliation, and political orientation. These variables are used to describe the sample and as control variables. The exact wording, response categories, and coding of these variables are provided in Appendix [X].

3.5 Data Quality and Processing.

Insufficient attention and careless responding can reduce the quality of data collected through self-administered online surveys, making procedures for identifying potentially low-quality responses important (Berinsky et al., 2014; Curran, 2016). The proposed survey would therefore include a simple instructed-response attention check and would record survey completion times. Available data-quality controls provided by Qualtrics and the Bilendi panel would additionally be used, where applicable, to identify duplicate or automated responses.

Respondents would be flagged for potential low-quality responding based on failure of the attention check or implausibly short completion times. The precise criteria for identifying such responses would be specified following pilot testing and prior to the main analysis. Rather than automatically excluding respondents based on a single indicator, the different indicators of response quality would be considered together. Robustness analyses could additionally examine whether the results are sensitive to the inclusion of respondents flagged for potential low-quality responding.

Data processing would distinguish between low-quality responses and legitimate missing or not-applicable responses. Displayed survey questions would generally require a response before respondents could proceed. Where appropriate, particularly for sensitive respondent characteristics, an explicit "prefer not to say" option would be provided. Missing values may therefore arise from such explicit non-response options or from conditional questions that are not displayed based on respondents' preceding answers. These values would not automatically result in respondent-level exclusion but would be treated according to the respective variable. Further details on the attention check, exclusion criteria, treatment and coding of missing responses, and construction of derived variables would be provided in Appendix [X].

4 Empirical Strategy

4.1 Experimental Analysis: Identification and Tests of H1–H3

The first part of the empirical analysis examines how the experimentally varied characteristics of the migrant profiles affect respondents' beliefs about migrants' labor-market and social integration outcomes. The unit of observation is a vignette evaluation, where respondent i evaluates migrant profile j . Since each respondent evaluates several migrant profiles, the analysis contains multiple observations for each respondent.

The factorial vignette design independently randomizes five characteristics across profiles: country of origin, reason for migration, gender, human capital, and German-language proficiency (see Chapter 3). Random assignment makes these characteristics independent of respondents' pre-existing characteristics and, in expectation, of the other randomized profile attributes. The experimental variation can therefore be used to identify the causal effect of each presented migrant characteristic on respondents' stated beliefs. In other words, the experiment identifies how respondents' beliefs change when one characteristic of the migrant profile changes. For example, it identifies how respondents' beliefs differ when an otherwise identical migrant is presented as Ukrainian rather than Syrian.

4.1.1 Variables and Baseline Specification

Baseline specification. The five outcome variables introduced in Section 3.3 are analyzed separately. Let Y_{ij}^k denote respondent i 's belief about outcome k for vignette profile j , where

$$k \in \{\text{Emp, Inc, Hire, Work, Soc}\}.$$

Y_{ij}^{Emp} denotes the expected probability of obtaining regular paid employment within two years, Y_{ij}^{Inc} denotes expected monthly net income, Y_{ij}^{Hire} and Y_{ij}^{Work} denote expected discrimination in hiring and in the workplace, respectively, and Y_{ij}^{Soc} denotes expected social integration.

The randomized vignette characteristics are represented by five binary variables. Ukr_j equals one if profile j describes a Ukrainian migrant and zero if the migrant is Syrian. Ref_j equals one if the migrant is presented as a war refugee and zero if the migrant is presented as an economic migrant. Fem_j equals one for a female migrant and zero for a male migrant. $HighSkill_j$ equals one if the migrant has completed a university degree and zero if the migrant has no formal vocational qualification. Finally, $German_j$ equals one if the migrant speaks German well and zero if the migrant speaks German only to a limited extent. These definitions imply that the reference profile is a male Syrian economic migrant without a formal vocational qualification who speaks German only to a limited extent.

For each outcome k , the baseline specification is

$$Y_{ij}^k = \alpha^k + \beta_1^k Ukr_j + \beta_2^k Ref_j + \beta_3^k Fem_j + \beta_4^k HighSkill_j + \beta_5^k German_j + \varepsilon_{ij}^k. \quad (1)$$

The coefficients β_1^k to β_5^k capture the average causal effects of the respective randomized vignette characteristics on outcome k , relative to their reference categories and averaging over the randomized values of the remaining profile characteristics. The baseline specifications are estimated using linear regression, and the interpretation of the coefficients depends on the respective outcome measure. For the employment outcome, which is measured on a 0–100 probability scale, coefficients are expressed in percentage points. For the income outcome, the seven ordered categories are coded from 1 to 7, so coefficients are expressed in income-category points rather than as specific differences in euros. For the remaining outcomes, which are measured on seven-point response scales, coefficients are expressed in scale points. Since the ordinal response categories cannot necessarily be assumed to be equally spaced, ordered logit models are additionally estimated as robustness checks. The term ε_{ij}^k denotes the error term and captures variation in respondent i 's evaluation of profile j for outcome k that is not explained by the variables included in the regression.

Adjusted specification. Because the vignette attributes are independently randomized, respondent-level controls are not required for identification of the coefficients in equation (1). The unadjusted specification therefore constitutes the main specification for estimating the experimental effects. As an adjusted specification, respondent background characteristics can additionally be included:

$$Y_{ij}^k = \alpha^k + \beta_1^k Ukr_j + \beta_2^k Ref_j + \beta_3^k Fem_j + \beta_4^k HighSkill_j + \beta_5^k German_j + \boldsymbol{\delta}^{k'} X_i + \varepsilon_{ij}^k. \quad (2)$$

where X_i is a vector of respondent-level controls including age, gender, education, employment status, household net income, migration background, region of residence in Germany, religion, and political self-placement, and is denoted by

$$X_i = (Age_i, Gender_i, Edu_i, Emp_i, Inc_i, Mig_i, East_i, Religion_i, Right_i)'$$

The inclusion of X_i does not provide the source of identification for the randomized vignette effects, but this adjusted specification can be used to assess the robustness and potentially improve the precision of the experimental estimates. The construction and use of the respondent-level controls are discussed further in Section 4.4.

Standard errors. Since each respondent evaluates multiple vignette profiles, observations belonging to the same respondent cannot be treated as statistically independent. Standard errors are therefore clustered at the respondent level in all vignette-level specifications, allowing the regression residuals to be correlated across the profiles evaluated by the same respondent. This accounts for the repeated-evaluation structure of the proposed experiment.

4.1.2 Main Effects: H1a, H1b, H2, H3a, and H3b

The baseline specification in equation (1) is used to test the main effects predicted in H1a, H1b, H2, H3a, and H3b. Since several hypotheses concern more than one outcome, the specification is estimated separately for each outcome relevant to the respective hypothesis. For each hypothesis, the predicted direction of the corresponding coefficients is specified below. The interpretation considers the direction and magnitude of the estimated effects as well as their statistical uncertainty, reported using 95% confidence intervals. If the results differ across outcomes, these differences are reported and discussed separately rather than assigning one overall conclusion to the hypothesis. The adjusted specification in equation (2) is additionally estimated as a robustness check.

Testing H1a. H1a predicts that migrants with higher human capital are expected to achieve more favorable labor-market integration outcomes. Equation (1) is therefore estimated for the employment and income outcomes, Y_{ij}^{Emp} and Y_{ij}^{Inc} . The coefficient of interest is β_4^k on $HighSkill_j$, which captures the causal effect of presenting a migrant with a university degree rather than with no formal vocational qualification on respondents' beliefs about the respective outcome. H1a predicts

$$\beta_4^{\text{Emp}} > 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \beta_4^{\text{Inc}} > 0.$$

Thus, positive coefficients indicate more favorable beliefs about the respective labor-market outcomes for profiles with higher human capital.

Testing H1b. H1b predicts that migrants with higher German-language proficiency are expected to achieve more favorable labor-market and social-integration outcomes. Equation (1) is therefore estimated Y_{ij}^{Emp} , Y_{ij}^{Inc} , and expected social integration Y_{ij}^{Soc} . The coefficient of interest is β_5^k on $German_j$, which captures the causal effect of presenting a migrant as speaking German well rather than only to a limited extent on respondents' beliefs. H1b predicts

$$\beta_5^{\text{Emp}} > 0, \quad \beta_5^{\text{Inc}} > 0, \quad \text{and} \quad \beta_5^{\text{Soc}} > 0.$$

Thus, positive coefficients indicate more favorable beliefs about the respective outcomes for profiles with higher German-language proficiency.

Testing H2. H2 predicts that refugees are expected to achieve less favorable labor-market integration outcomes than otherwise comparable economic migrants. Equation (1) is estimated for Y_{ij}^{Emp} and Y_{ij}^{Inc} . The coefficient of interest is β_2^k on Ref_j , which captures the causal effect of presenting a migrant as a war refugee rather than as an economic migrant on respondents' beliefs. H2 predicts

$$\beta_2^{\text{Emp}} < 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \beta_2^{\text{Inc}} < 0.$$

Thus, negative coefficients indicate less favorable beliefs about the respective outcomes for profiles presented as refugees rather than economic migrants.

Testing H3a. H3a predicts that Ukrainian migrants are expected to achieve more favorable labor-market and social-integration outcomes than otherwise comparable Syrian migrants. Equation (1) is estimated for Y_{ij}^{Emp} , Y_{ij}^{Inc} , and Y_{ij}^{Soc} . The coefficient of interest is β_1^k on Ukr_j , which captures the causal effect of presenting a migrant as Ukrainian rather than Syrian on respondents' beliefs. H3a predicts

$$\beta_1^{\text{Emp}} > 0, \quad \beta_1^{\text{Inc}} > 0, \quad \text{and} \quad \beta_1^{\text{Soc}} > 0.$$

Thus, positive coefficients indicate more favorable beliefs about the respective outcomes for profiles presented as Ukrainian rather than Syrian.

Testing H3b. H3b examines country-of-origin differences in expected labor-market discrimination and predicts that Syrian migrants are expected to face greater discrimination than otherwise comparable Ukrainian migrants. The hypothesis is tested using the country-of-origin indicator, Ukr_j , with Y_{ij}^{Hire} and Y_{ij}^{Work} as the dependent variables. An important difference from the preceding outcomes is that higher values of both discrimination measures indicate a less favorable outcome, namely greater expected discrimination. Since Syria is the reference category and $Ukr_j = 1$ represents Ukraine, H3b therefore predicts

$$\beta_1^{\text{Hire}} < 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \beta_1^{\text{Work}} < 0.$$

Negative coefficients thus indicate that profiles presented as Ukrainian are expected to face less hiring and workplace discrimination than otherwise comparable Syrian profiles.

4.1.3 Interaction Effects: H3c and Additional Analysis

Testing H3c. While H3a and H3b examine average country-of-origin differences in expected integration and discrimination outcomes, H3c examines whether the size of these differences varies systematically between the two reasons for migration. Specifically, H3c predicts that differences between Ukrainian and Syrian migrants are greater when migrants are presented as refugees than when they are presented as economic migrants.

To test this hypothesis, an interaction term between country of origin and reason for migration is added to the baseline specification:

$$Y_{ij}^k = \alpha^k + \beta_1^k Ukr_j + \beta_2^k Ref_j + \beta_3^k Fem_j + \beta_4^k HighSkill_j + \beta_5^k German_j + \beta_6^k (Ukr_j \times Ref_j) + \varepsilon_{ij}^k. \quad (3)$$

Since $Ref_j = 0$ represents economic migrants, β_1^k captures the Ukrainian–Syrian difference among economic migrants. When $Ref_j = 1$, the corresponding Ukrainian–Syrian difference among refugees is given by $\beta_1^k + \beta_6^k$. Thus, β_6^k captures how the country-of-origin difference changes when migrants are presented as refugees rather than economic

migrants. For employment, income, and social integration, higher values represent more favorable outcomes and H3c therefore predicts

$$\beta_6^{\text{Emp}} > 0, \quad \beta_6^{\text{Inc}} > 0, \quad \beta_6^{\text{Soc}} > 0.$$

For hiring and workplace discrimination, higher values instead represent greater expected discrimination. Since Ukrainian migrants are expected to face less discrimination, a larger country-of-origin difference among refugees corresponds to a more negative Ukrainian–Syrian difference. H3c therefore predicts

$$\beta_6^{\text{Hire}} < 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \beta_6^{\text{Work}} < 0.$$

In addition to the interaction coefficient, the conditional country-of-origin difference among refugees, $\beta_1^k + \beta_6^k$, is reported together with its 95% confidence interval. This shows whether the Ukrainian–Syrian difference among refugees itself is in the direction predicted by H3a and H3b, while β_6^k tests whether this difference is greater among refugees than among economic migrants.

Additional human-capital analysis. In addition to H3c, the analysis similarly explores whether the Ukrainian–Syrian difference in expected integration outcomes varies with migrants’ human capital. For this purpose, the equation (1) is extended separately by the interaction $Ukr_j \times HighSkill_j$. If higher human capital reduces the Ukrainian–Syrian gap in expected integration outcomes, the coefficient on this interaction is expected to be negative. This analysis is treated as supporting rather than as a separate hypothesis.

4.2 Associational Analysis: Contact, Experience, Media, and Memory

4.2.1 Contact and Experience

4.2.2 Media Exposure

4.2.3 Memorable Experiences and Information

4.3 General Beliefs and Exploratory Analyses

4.4 Robustness, Data Treatment, and Interpretation

Citing measurement sources for the respondent questionnaire: C_{ig}^{Work} workplace contact frequency, C_{ig}^{Social} social contact frequency, Q_{ig} contact quality.

Beliefs about large communities and network effects:

Large community → More information/referrals → Better employment
versus

Large community → Less native interaction → Slower integration.

Construct:

$$\Delta B_i^{\text{Network}} = B_{i,\text{S}}^{\text{Network}} - B_{i,\text{U}}^{\text{Network}}$$

5 Limitations and Extensions

5.1 Extensions

5.2 Limitations and Identification Constraints

6 Conclusion

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A Appendix A: Proposed Survey Instrument

what to add here: vignette instructions, exact vignette template, all six outcome questions with every response option, contact/experience questions, media questions, general-belief questions, demographics, and attention checks.

Should I also make a survey in Qualtrics and include a link to it here? Or add screenshots of the survey questions which I create in Qualtrics?

Statement of Authorship

I hereby confirm that the work presented has been performed and interpreted solely by myself except for where I explicitly identified the contrary. I assure that this work has not been presented in any other form for the fulfillment of any other degree or qualification. Ideas taken from other works in letter and in spirit are identified in every single case.

Date:

Signature: